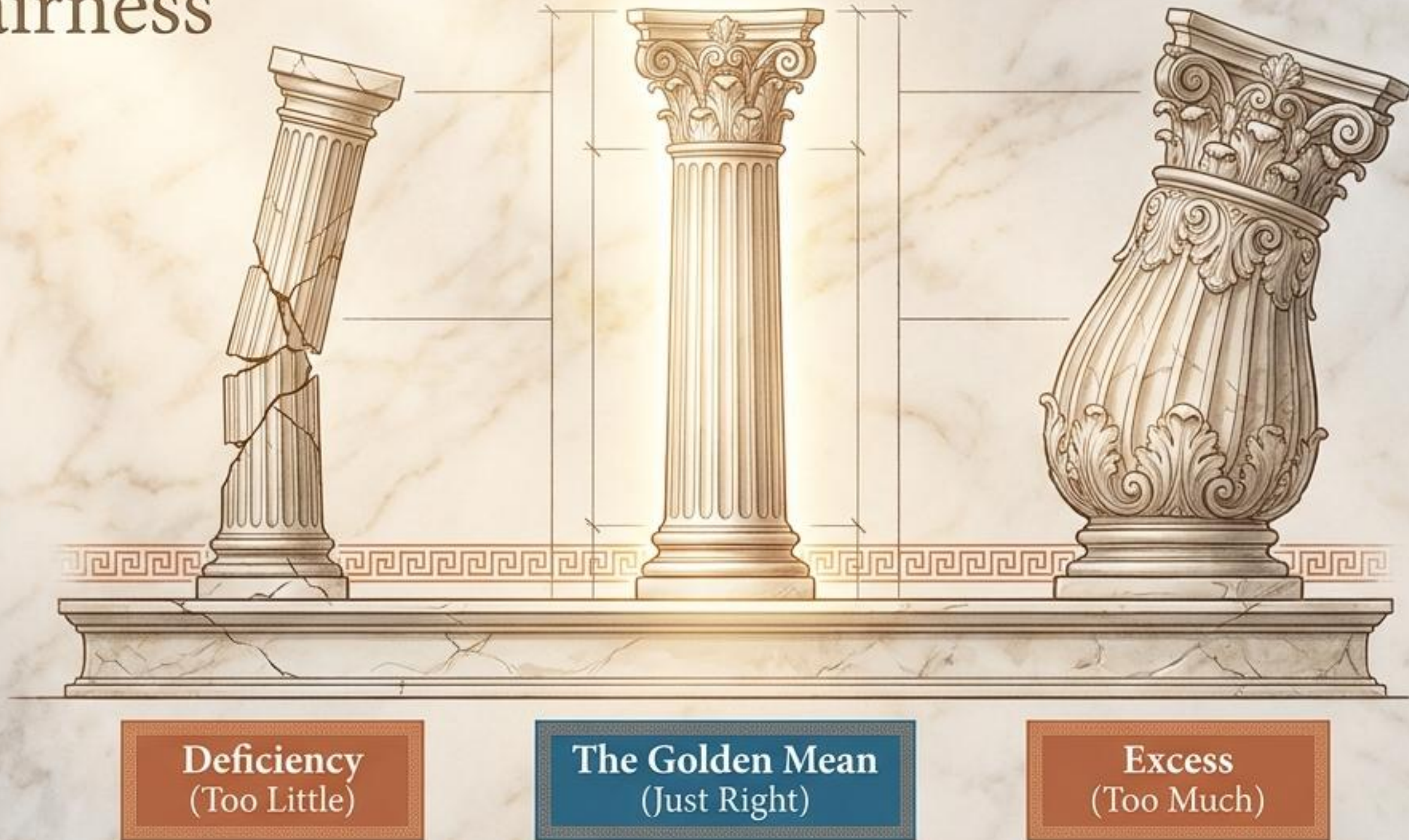


The Anatomy of Righteous Indignation



Finding the Aristotelian Mean in the
aftermath of a modern romantic breakup.

The Architecture of Moral Fairness



True virtue is constantly tested when relationships end.
Maintaining our moral gravity requires balancing our emotional extremes.

The Catalyst: A Shattered Vow



The Betrayal

A marriage ends because one partner was unfaithful.

The Aftermath

The unfaithful partner quickly moves in with a new lover.

The Illusion

The newly formed couple appears to be deliriously happy.

The Deficiency: Spitefulness

Taking pleasure in pain.

The Reaction: The betrayed spouse feels a “dark, secret joy” upon hearing the new couple is already arguing.

The Flaw: They do not want their former partner back, but they are nourished by the misery of the situation.

Moral Status: They lack appropriate moral gravity.



The Excess: Envy

Resenting the innocent.

The Reaction: The betrayed spouse looks at a completely different, innocent friend who is happily married, and feels a “bitter ache.”

The Flaw: They are angry not at the cheater, but at the faithful friend, simply because the friend possesses the stable love that they lost.

Moral Status: An overflow of misplaced emotion.



The Golden Mean: Righteous Indignation

Justified anger without malice.

The Reaction: The betrayed spouse feels a deep, justified anger specifically at the violation of the marriage vows.

Moral Status: They simply recognize a moral wrong.

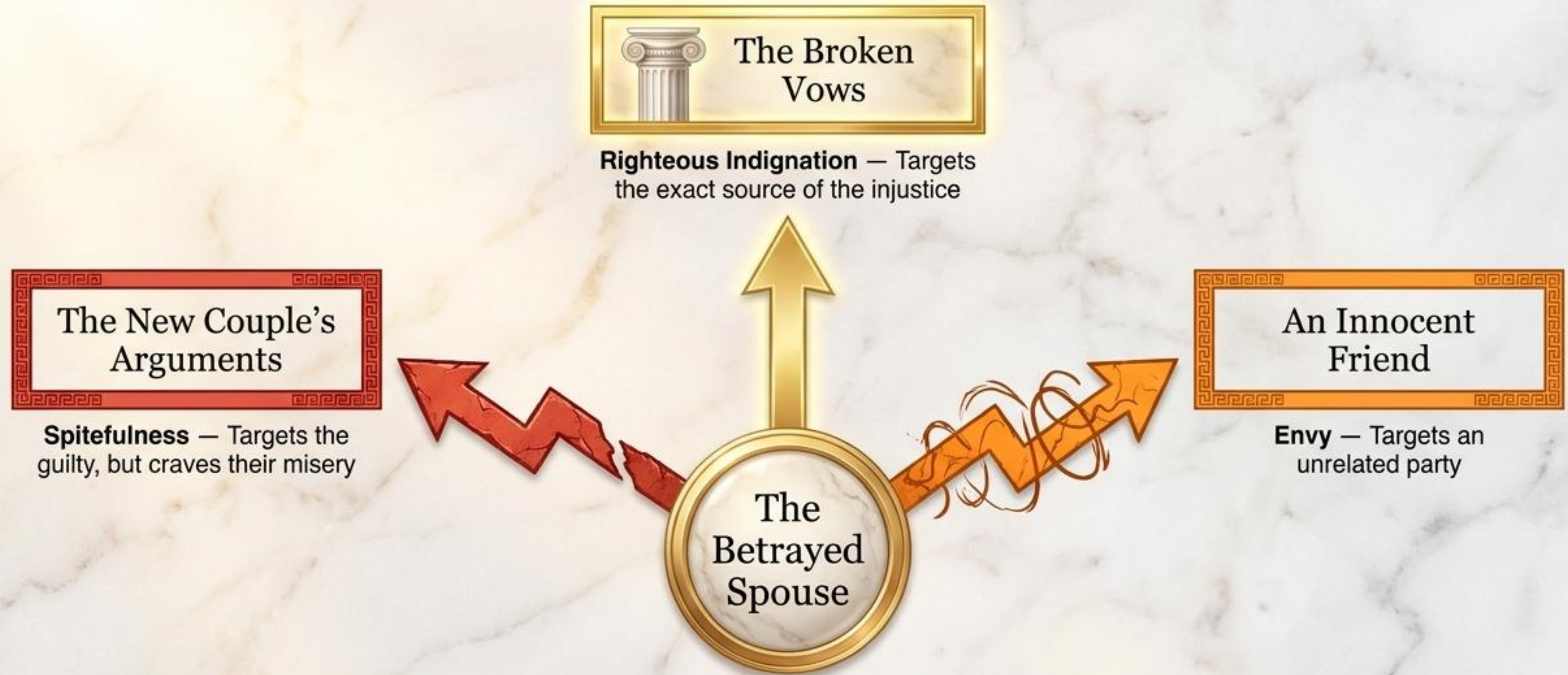
The Virtue: They are pained by the injustice of the betrayal, but they do not wish harm on the new couple, nor do they resent the happy people around them.



The Matrix of Moral Reactions

	Spitefulness (Deficiency)	Righteous Indignation (Mean)	Envy (Excess)
Core Emotional State	Feels a “dark, secret joy”	Feels a deep, justified anger	Feels a “bitter ache”
Target of Emotion	The misery of the new couple	The injustice of the betrayal itself	An innocent, happily married friend
Status of Integrity	Lacks moral gravity (Takes pleasure in pain)	Integrity intact (Recognizes a moral wrong)	Misplaced anger (Resents stable love)

Diagnosing the Target of Emotion



Insight: Virtue is determined not just by the intensity of our feelings, but by where we aim them.

Walking Away with Integrity

They simply recognize a moral
wrong and walk away with their
integrity intact.

The Golden Mean does not demand we ignore
our pain; it demands we carry it with dignity.